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Managing Organisational Changes for Collaboration Between Stakeholders in Sustainable Public Procurement

Felippe Santos | Per Hilletofth | Robin von Haartman

Faculty of Engineering and Sustainable Development, University of Gävle, Gävle, Sweden

Correspondence: Felippe Santos (felippe.santos@hig.se)

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ABSTRACT

Sustainable public procurement (SPP) has been incorporating sustainability issues into commercial relationships between governments and businesses. SPP implementation can be undertaken with the support of organisational changes. Research has highlighted the role of stakeholders' collaboration in driving changes for SPP. However, there is limited understanding of the forces fostering and blocking the implementation of collaboration. This paper analyses drivers for and barriers to implementing collaboration in SPP, based on semi-structured interviews with SPP practitioners from different world regions (Brazil and Sweden). This paper provides a catalogue of forces influencing organisational changes towards collaboration in SPP (categorised into internal, connecting-protagonist, connecting-supporting and external), including 23 drivers, 40 barriers and 24 strategies to overcome such barriers. This paper also proposes an understanding of how organisational changes for collaboration are interconnected with changes for implementing SPP. Organisational changes for SPP must be understood as multiple and composite instead of single and monolithic.

1 | Introduction

Sustainable public procurement (SPP) has been contributing to sustainable development efforts (UNEP 2022; WHO 2022) by incorporating sustainability issues into commercial relationships between public buyers (e.g., municipalities and government agencies) and suppliers (i.e., businesses) (Brammer and Walker 2011; van Berkel and Schotanus 2021). SPP is aimed at fostering sustainable consumption and production (Grandia 2016; Preuss 2009) through the use of governments' purchasing power (McCrudden 2004; Prier, Schwerin, and McCue 2016), in alignment with the United Nations Agenda 2030 Sustainable Development Goals (UNEP 2023; United Nations 2015). SPP initiatives can potentially address economic (e.g., Van Assche et al. 2023; Malacina et al. 2022), environmental (see Parikka-Alhola 2008; Sparrevik et al. 2018), and social (e.g., Martin-Ortega 2018; Sattari et al. 2022) issues, contributing to developing sustainable societies (Meehan and Bryde 2011; UNEP 2017).

Several elements compose SPP initiatives (see Lozano, Santos, and Barreiro 2024), including sustainability dimensions (Meehan and Bryde 2011; Preuss 2009) and stakeholder interactions (Holma et al. 2020; Witjes and Lozano 2016). SPP initiatives have also been composed of disciplinary approaches aimed at supporting and providing a complete understanding of SPP implementation (Lozano, Santos, and Barreiro 2024), such as economic (Chiappinelli and Seres 2024; Tarantini, Loprieno, and Porta 2011), legal (Caranta 2022; Sanchez-Graells 2018), and public policy (Daugbjerg 2023; Wesseling and Edquist 2018) approaches. Managerial approaches have also contributed to SPP initiatives (Lingegård and von Oelreich 2023; Oruezabala and Rico 2012), including efforts to manage and understand

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organisational changes for SPP (Brammer and Walker 2011; Grandia, Steijn, and Kuipers 2015).

Changes have been part of organisations: to survive and prosper (Armenakis and Harris 2009; Meyer and Stensaker 2006), to increase organisational efficiency (Kuipers et al. 2014), to contribute to sustainability efforts (Doppelt 2010; Dunphy, Griffiths, and Benn 2003), and because changes are inherent in human actions (and organisations are comprised of human actions) (Tsoukas and Chia 2002). Organisational change management (OCM) has been providing an understanding of how organisations can change, that is, move from *status quos* to more desirable states (Rosenbaum, More, and Steane 2018; Stouten, Rousseau, and De Cremer 2018). Research on OCM for SPP has been studying changes aimed at moving organisations to a state of implementing SPP (Brammer and Walker 2011; Prier, Schwerin, and McCue 2016), mainly focusing on analysing forces contributing to (i.e., drivers) (Amann et al. 2014; Leal Filho et al. 2019) and hindering changes (i.e., barriers) (Delmonico et al. 2018; Vejaratnam, Mohamad, and Chenayah 2020).

Several drivers for SPP have been proposed by the literature, including policy and guidelines (Allen 2021; van Berkel and Schotanus 2021), personnel's commitment to sustainability (Grandia, Steijn, and Kuipers 2015; Leal Filho et al. 2019), and collaboration between stakeholders (Betiol et al. 2015; Sattari et al. 2022). Collaboration between stakeholders in SPP can contribute to developing procurement requirements (Bortz et al. 2024; Testa et al. 2012), providing a mutual understanding of needs (Alhola and Nissinen 2018; Uttam and Roos 2015), and sharing ownership of solutions (Sonnino 2009; Witjes and Lozano 2016). However, implementing collaboration between stakeholders in SPP also requires organisational changes (Erridge and Greer 2002), but there is limited research focusing on how organisations can change towards developing collaborative SPP initiatives. There is also little to no research providing an understanding of the intersections between organisational changes for SPP and changes for collaboration in the SPP context—changes for SPP are usually understood as a single and monolithic process.

This paper aims to provide depth to the OCM approach for SPP—by exploring forces influencing organisational changes towards collaboration—while analysing the interconnection between changes towards SPP and changes for collaboration, focusing on a more plural and systemic perspective.

This paper is structured as follows: Section 2 presents the literature review, focusing on managing organisational changes for SPP and changes towards collaborative SPP. Section 3 shows this research's method, based on an inductive approach and semi-structured interviews. Section 4 presents the findings from the empirical data. Section 5 discusses the findings and provides a better understanding of organisational changes towards collaboration between stakeholders in SPP. Section 6 presents the conclusions and suggests further research topics.

2 | Organisational Changes for Collaborative SPP

Organisations change by moving from unsatisfactory states (i.e., *status quos*) to more desirable (i.e., improved) states (By 2005; Ragsdell 2000), through change processes that can be represented by Lewin's (1947) proposal—in which organisations unfreeze the initial state, move and refreeze on the improved state. The change process—a challenging voyage (Mento, Jones, and Dirndorfer 2002)—can be influenced by several systemic elements, such as organisational culture (Harris and Crane 2002) and resistance to change (Ford, Ford, and D'Amelio 2008). Internal (e.g., employees) and external (e.g., politicians, government agencies, and non-governmental organisations) stakeholders can also influence this change process (Doppelt 2010). Preparatory steps can increase the chances of this process's success by developing organisational capacity for change (Dunphy, Griffiths, and Benn 2003; Supriharyanti and Sukoco 2023). According to Meyer and Stensaker (2006), organisational capacity for change has at least three dimensions: capability to implement the change, capability to maintain the operations, and capability to implement subsequent (i.e., future) changes. Change processes can also be influenced by bundled and reinforced changes (Stouten, Rousseau, and De Cremer 2018), considering the interconnection of multiple change processes and their contextual factors (Pettigrew, Woodman, and Cameron 2001).

OCM literature has been proposing several approaches to understanding organisational changes (By 2005; Da Ros, Vainieri, and Bellé 2023), including planned and emergent changes (Bamford and Forrester 2003; Kuipers et al. 2014). Planned changes include pre-planned steps (e.g., frameworks) and force field analysis (Bamford and Forrester 2003; Rosenbaum, More, and Steane 2018), following a top-down implementation (Van der Voet 2014). Emergent changes are more adaptative, continuous, flexible, and incremental than planned (Stouten, Rousseau, and De Cremer 2018), considering bottom-up implementation processes (Van der Voet 2014).

OCM has been contributing to understanding changes in contexts such as gender equality (Johansson and Ringblom 2017; Meyerson and Kolb 2000), public management (Kuipers et al. 2014; Van der Voet 2014), and sustainability (Doppelt 2010; Dunphy, Griffiths, and Benn 2003). Changes towards sustainability require planned and orchestrated changes (Lozano 2012), considering organisations as whole systems (Doppelt 2010) that need to promote successive changes to be more oriented towards sustainability (which is a dynamic state) (Lozano 2007; Martin, Brannigan, and Hall 2005). Change processes towards sustainability can be supported by frameworks through which organisations can continuously disrupt their *status quos* to achieve more desirable (i.e., sustainability-oriented) states (Lozano 2007). These change processes can be improved through the involvement of internal (i.e., employees) and external stakeholders (Doppelt 2010).

Managing changes for sustainability requires an understanding of drivers for, barriers to sustainability, and strategies to overcome such barriers (Govindan and Hasanagic 2018; Lozano 2012)—for example, Lozano's (2007) proposed a framework considering these forces in orchestrating changes towards sustainability. Drivers are forces pushing changes forward and sustaining changes (Harris and Crane 2002). Barriers are forces blocking or hindering the change efforts (Giunipero, Hooker, and Denslow 2012). Strategies are additional forces developed to overcome barriers to change (Doppelt 2010; Lozano 2012).

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These forces have been categorised in the OCM for sustainability literature mainly into internal and external to the organisation (Dunphy, Griffiths, and Benn 2003; Engert, Rauter, and Baumgartner 2016; Rauter, Jonker, and Baumgartner 2017). An internal-connecting-external categorisation (proposed by Lozano 2015; Lozano et al. 2019) offered a more complete understanding of the topic by organising such forces considering stakeholder influence, into more dependent on internal stakeholders and proactive (internal), more dependent on external stakeholders and reactive (external), and more related to efforts dependent on both internal and external stakeholders (connecting).

Research on OCM for sustainability has explored several contexts, such as circular economy (Govindan and Hasanagic 2018; Klein, Ramos, and Deutz 2022), corporate sustainability (Dunphy, Griffiths, and Benn 2003; Lozano 2007), and SPP (Brammer and Walker 2011; Cheng et al. 2018). OCM for SPP has been developing knowledge on drivers for (Amann et al. 2014; Grandia, Steijn, and Kuipers 2015), barriers to changes towards implementing SPP (Brammer and Walker 2011; Delmonico et al. 2018), and strategies to overcome such barriers (Leal Filho et al. 2019; Testa et al. 2016).

Drivers for implementing SPP include clear and supportive regulations (Brammer and Walker 2011; Smith et al. 2016), personnel's commitment to sustainability (Grandia, Steijn, and Kuipers 2015; Leal Filho et al. 2019), and policy and guidelines (Allen 2021; van Berkel and Schotanus 2021)—a catalogue of 51 drivers was proposed by Santos, Lozano, and Barreiro-Gen (2024). Barriers to SPP encompass lack of financial resources (Brammer and Walker 2011; Leal Filho et al. 2019), lack of sustainability-friendly suppliers (Mendonça, Pedrosa, and Camara 2021; Oruezabala and Rico 2012), and lack of training (Berg et al. 2022; Betiol et al. 2015). Strategies to overcome barriers to SPP include assessment and reporting routine (Leal Filho et al. 2019; Meehan and Bryde 2011), empowerment of procurement officers (Eikelboom, Gelderman, and Semeijn 2018), and mandatory regulations (Zhu, Geng, and Sarkis 2013).

A key driver for organisational changes towards implementing SPP is collaboration between stakeholders (Betiol et al. 2015; Preuss 2009; Sattari et al. 2022), that is, joint actions aimed at proposing common solutions to shared problems (Gray 1985; Vangen and Huxham 2003). Collaboration between stakeholders has been contributing to implementing SPP through the co-development of procurement requirements (Bortz et al. 2024; Testa et al. 2012), mutual understanding of needs (Alhola and Nissinen 2018; Uttam and Roos 2015), shared ownership of solutions (Sonnino 2009; Witjes and Lozano 2016), and best practices dissemination (Berg et al. 2022; Lingegård et al. 2021). However, although there is previous research proposing that implementing collaboration in SPP initiatives also requires organisational changes (Erridge and Greer 2002), there is limited research providing an understanding of how organisations can change towards implementing collaborative SPP initiatives.

Research on collaboration in SPP has been proposing drivers that contribute to implementing collaboration in this context: for instance, clear roles (Bortz et al. 2024; Johnson and Klassen 2022), champions (Lingegård et al. 2021; Lozano et al. 2020), and demand-offering of needs (i.e., buyer demanding and supplier offering needs fulfilment that may include products, services and functions, as described by Lozano, Santos, and Barreiro 2024) (Lozano et al. 2020; Uttam and Roos 2015). Barriers hindering collaboration efforts in SPP include lack of collaboration commitment (Erridge and Greer 2002), lack of supportive regulations (Edquist and Zabala-Iturriagagoitia 2012; Lingegård et al. 2021), and lack of trust (Erridge and Greer 2002; Sonnino 2009). Strategies to overcome such barriers include participative-building policies and training (see Erridge and Greer 2002). However, the literature has not yet categorised and organised these forces to provide a more complete understanding of the topic.

The drivers for, barriers to collaboration in SPP, and strategies to overcome such barriers according to the literature are presented in Tables 1–3, respectively. In these tables, the forces were categorised into internal, connecting, and external (as proposed by Lozano 2015; Lozano et al. 2019).

3 | Methods

This research uses grounded theory (GT) as a method for deriving theory from the data (see Corbin and Strauss 1998; Glaser and Strauss 1967), contributing to the development of the OCM approach to SPP. GT is aimed at analysing, understanding, and explaining social phenomena using qualitative data (Corbin and Strauss 1998; McNabb 2015), allowing simultaneous efforts

TABLE 1 | Drivers for collaboration between stakeholders in SPP according to the literature.

Level	Driver	Sources
Connecting	Clear roles	Bortz et al. (2024), Johnson and Klassen (2022)
	Innovation hub	Johnson and Klassen (2022)
Internal	Champions	Lingegård et al. (2021), Lozano et al. (2020)
	Collaboration-friendly policy	Johnson and Klassen (2022)
	Demand-offering of needs	Lozano et al. (2020), Uttam and Roos (2015)
	Discretion	Sparrevik et al. (2018)
	Leadership	Lingegård et al. (2021)
	Long planning phase	Alhola and Nissinen (2018), Sparrevik et al. (2018)
	Socio-cultural specifications	Alhola and Nissinen (2018)
	Stakeholder mapping	Alhola and Nissinen (2018), Holma et al. (2020), Johnson and Klassen (2022)

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TABLE 2 | Barriers to collaboration between stakeholders in SPP according to the literature.

Level	Barrier	Sources
External	Lack of competitive market	Preuss and Walker (2011)
	Lack of supportive regulations	Edquist and Zabala-Iturriagagoitia (2012), Erridge and Greer (2002), Lingegård et al. (2021)
Connecting	Lack of clear roles	Bratt et al. (2013), Holma et al. (2020)
	Lack of early involvement	Holma et al. (2020)
	Lack of expectations alignment	Sattari et al. (2022)
	Lack of informal arrangements	Erridge and Greer (2002)
	Lack of initiative hub	Preuss and Walker (2011)
	Lack of interaction transparency	Bratt et al. (2013)
	Lack of participative-building internal policies	Erridge and Greer (2002)
	Lack of sustainability alignment	Bratt et al. (2013)
	Lack of trust	Erridge and Greer (2002), Sonnino (2009)
Internal	Lack of category knowledge	Edquist and Zabala-Iturriagagoitia (2012), Lingegård et al. (2021)
	Lack of collaboration commitment	Erridge and Greer (2002)
	Lack of common goals	Erridge and Greer (2002), Preuss and Walker (2011)
	Lack of employee retention	Erridge and Greer (2002)
	Lack of long-term thinking	Bratt et al. (2013)
	Lack of positive inertia	Erridge and Greer (2002)
	Lack of risk-taking behaviour	Erridge and Greer (2002), Holma et al. (2020)
	Lack of strategic positioning of procurement	Erridge and Greer (2002)
	Lack of time	Holma et al. (2020), Lingegård et al. (2021)
	Lack of training	Erridge and Greer (2002), Holma et al. (2020), Preuss and Walker (2011)

TABLE 3 | Strategies to overcome barriers to collaboration between stakeholders in SPP according to the literature.

Level	Strategy	Sources
Connecting	Participative-building internal policies	Erridge and Greer (2002)
Internal	Discretion	Erridge and Greer (2002)
	Professionalisation of procurement staff	Erridge and Greer (2002)
	Strategic positioning of procurement	Erridge and Greer (2002)
	Training	Erridge and Greer (2002)

in data collection and data analysis (Corbin and Strauss 1998; Saunders, Lewis, and Thornhill 2019).

This research analysed the social phenomenon of collaboration between stakeholders in the SPP context through a comparative approach aimed at building a more complete understanding of the topic—based on interpreting data collected in two different contexts (see Ragin 2014). This research offers a cross-sectional comparison between data collected from two different countries, focusing on identifying similarities and differences in the studied social phenomena. This comparison contributes to providing a holistic approach to organisational changes in SPP, including an analysis of context influence on collaboration in SPP. This analysis based on different contexts also contributes to answering a call for developing comparative studies on SPP implementation (Cheng et al. 2018; Sattari et al. 2022; Vejaratnam, Mohamad, and Chenayah 2020).

The SPP contexts used in the data collection efforts were a developing country (Brazil) and a developed one (Sweden) that have been fostering SPP initiatives (UNEP 2017; World Bank 2021) but have different approaches to changes towards SPP (see Santos, Lozano, and Barreiro-Gen 2024). These countries have distinct legal frameworks and bureaucratic cultures influencing SPP implementation—which leverage the potential to understand the studied phenomenon in different contexts. For instance, Brazil has been promoting SPP initiatives through an approach based on practical efforts (i.e., focusing on initiatives from practitioners) (Delmonico et al. 2018). In Brazil, SPP has been mainly based on mandatory regulations

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supported by control agencies monitoring (i.e., more coercive power), focusing on practitioner efforts due to structural gaps at national and local levels (Mazzucato, Spanó, and Doyle 2024; Oliveira, Simão, and Caeiro 2020). Sweden has been supporting SPP initiatives through a policy-based approach (i.e., more related to national policies and structures) (Daugbjerg 2023; Sattari et al. 2022). In Sweden, SPP is mainly based on non-mandatory regulations supported by national structures and policies, depending on local willingness to set and implement their own goals (i.e., more discretionary power) (Bryngemark, Söderholm, and Thörn 2023; Daugbjerg 2023; Hunka et al. 2023).

Semi-structured interviews with SPP professionals were used to collect empirical data in this research, aiming to delve into the analysed phenomenon with flexibility (c.f. Saunders, Lewis, and Thornhill 2019). Twenty-two interviews were carried out: 12 with Brazilian and 10 with Swedish professionals. Table 4 presents the interviewees' professional profiles. The criteria used to select the interviewees included: they should have recently (1) worked with SPP at any governmental level (national, regional, and local); (2) positioned at public organisations acting as public buyers in SPP initiatives, and (3) contributed to implementing SPP in their organisations. In total, 15 different public organisations (9 Brazilians and 6 Swedish) were represented in the set of interviewees. Theoretical sampling was used to select potential interviewees, considering an initial idea of where to sample (e.g., SPP practitioners from Brazil and Sweden), choosing participants as they were needed (accessing interviewees through the academic and professional networks of the authors), and expanding the sample following GT's data analysis development (see Saunders, Lewis, and Thornhill 2019). The sample expansion was also complemented through a volunteer basis—snowball sampling (see Sapsford and Jupp 2006; Schutt 2012), with some participants identifying further potential interviewees to facilitate access. The data collection was finished when conceptual saturation was reached (see Corbin and Strauss 2008; Saunders, Lewis, and Thornhill 2019).

The interviews ranged between 45 min and 2 h and were conducted from October 2022 to May 2023. Most of the interviews (20) were done digitally (via Zoom), while 2 were conducted in person. The interviews were carried out in two different languages: Portuguese (for the Brazilian interviewees) and English (for the Swedish ones). After transcription, the interviewees were coded to guarantee anonymity: the Brazilian professionals were identified with a BR followed by a number (e.g., BR1 and BR2) and the Swedish ones with SE followed by a number.

The data collected was analysed using GT's constant comparative method, based on four stages (Corbin and Strauss 1998): (1) coding, (2) building categories, (3) integrating central categories, and (4) developing a grounded theory. At the coding stage, the data collected through the semi-structured interviews was coded (e.g., creating conceptual headings on forces influencing organisational changes for collaboration in SPP), following a constant comparison between the codes aimed at understanding their similarities and differences. At this stage, concepts emerging from the literature review were

TABLE 4 | Professional profiles of SPP practitioners interviewed.

Code	Position	Organisation level	Years working with public procurement
BR1	Audit officer	National	24
BR2	Procurement manager	National	16
BR3	Procurement officer	National	9
BR4	Strategic advisor	National	20
BR5	Chief procurement officer	National	17
BR6	Audit manager	National	7
BR7	Procurement manager	National	12
BR8	Strategic advisor	National	22
BR9	Chief procurement officer	Regional	15
BR10	Procurement officer	National	15
BR11	Strategic advisor	National	11
BR12	Chief procurement officer	National	16
SE1	Procurement officer	Local	20
SE2	Sustainability officer	National	7
SE3	Chief sustainability officer	National	4
SE4	Chief executive officer	National	10
SE5	Project manager	Regional	14
SE6	Sustainability manager	Local	5
SE7	Project manager	Regional	11
SE8	Chief procurement officer	Local	25

(Continues)

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TABLE 4 | (Continued)

Code	Position	Organisation level	Years working with public procurement
SE9	Chief procurement officer	Regional	5
SE10	Sustainability manager	Regional	7

used as another data source (e.g., forces identified in previous research); however, these concepts were coded after the conceptual headings were built from the empirical data. At the building categories stage, categories and subcategories were created by the identification of relationships between the codes (e.g., organising forces into the internal-connecting-external categorisation)—and these categories were continuously compared with the data. At the integrating central categories stage, central categories and their properties were identified and integrated (e.g., drivers for, barriers to collaboration in SPP, and strategies to overcome such barriers). At the final stage (i.e., developing a GT), a new understanding of organisational changes for collaboration in SPP was built considering the categories and their relationships. The data were analysed with the support of the software NVivo 1.0 (QSR 2020).

3.1 | Method Limitations

The use of interviews to collect data poses limitations to this research's method, potentially affecting the reliability and validity of the research findings (as proposed by Saunders, Lewis, and Thornhill 2019). These limitations are mainly related to the interviewees' selection criteria, the interviewer's engagement with the research topic, the limited number of interviews, and the use of a second language during data collection. The selection criteria of the interviewees (e.g., practitioners engaged with SPP) may induce a participation bias. The interviewer's engagement with SPP may be a threat related to observer bias. The limited number of interviews may limit the generalisability or external validity of the findings. The use of a second language during data collection—English while interviewing Swedish professionals—may result in cultural and language nuances that can affect interactions with the interviewees and interpretation of the data.

The interview design included questions regarding sustainability understanding, SPP implementation, collaboration in SPP, and implementing collaboration in SPP—the latter entailing discussions on drivers, barriers, and strategies to overcome barriers. However, the questions and interview development were not aimed at discussing direct relationships between strategies and barriers (e.g., which strategies are aimed to overcome a specific barrier), which limits the depth of this topic's analysis.

Another limitation of this research's methods is related to the use of previous research to complement a GT's data analysis (see Tummers and Karsten 2012). Previous research can be used in GT to identify research gaps, improve theoretical sensitivity, enhance categorisation, and extend the body of knowledge (as proposed by Corbin and Strauss 1998; Creswell 2009; Mills, Bonner, and Francis 2006). However, using previous research in GT can threaten the quality of the research by blocking new insights, overlooking issues pointed out by previous studies, and selecting data following findings mentioned by the literature. In this research, strategies to overcome such threats included reviewing the literature throughout the entire research process (e.g., during the data collection and analysis) and categorising this literature (e.g., drivers, barriers, and strategies) after the data.

4 | Findings

4.1 | Drivers for Collaboration in SPP

The interviewees mentioned 18 drivers for implementing collaboration in SPP (listed in Table 5), which can be organised into internal, connecting, and external. At the internal level, 12 drivers were mentioned: (1) balanced workload, (2) champions, (3) collaboration commitment, (4) collaboration-friendly policy,

TABLE 5 | Drivers for collaboration between stakeholders in SPP according to the interviewees.

Level	Driver	Sources
External	Clear and supportive regulations	BR2, SE10
	Market willingness	SE10
Connecting	Control agencies' support	BR9
	Political support	BR9
	Political visibility	BR4, BR10
	Shared procurement system	BR2
Internal	Balanced workload	BR10
	Champions	BR4, BR10, SE3
	Collaboration commitment	BR4, SE1, SE2, SE3, SE5, SE6, SE7, SE9
	Collaboration-friendly policy	BR2
	Dedicated staff	SE5, SE7
	Innovation culture	BR6
	Leadership	BR4, BR9, SE3
	Long planning phase	SE7
	Multidisciplinary team	BR8, SE2, SE3, SE7
	Positive inertia	SE2, SE5, SE7
	Professional visibility	BR10
	Stakeholder mapping	BR6, SE6

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(5) dedicated staff, (6) innovation culture, (7) leadership, (8) long planning phase, (9) multidisciplinary team, (10) positive inertia, (11) professional visibility, and (12) stakeholder mapping. These internal drivers depend mainly on internal efforts to be developed.

The most mentioned drivers at the internal level were collaboration commitment (eight mentions), multidisciplinary team (four mentions), champions (three mentions), leadership (three mentions), and positive inertia (three mentions). Collaboration commitment includes personnel's commitment to work collaboratively, dialoguing with internal and external stakeholders and developing networks as a standard work behaviour. Multidisciplinary team comprises joint efforts between professionals from different departments (e.g., procurement, sustainability, and procurement category management) through a formal team (e.g., procurement planning team and reference group) aimed at carrying out procurement activities—such as developing procurement requirements (e.g., specifications of products and services and award criteria), interacting with stakeholders, and conducting procurement planning (e.g., assessing market availability, pricing, and writing tender documents). Champions stand for experienced and trained professionals capable of steering organisations through the legal and bureaucratic pathways to collaborate in SPP. Leadership entails an active role of leaders in promoting collaboration and engaging stakeholders, using their organisational mandate towards a more interactive procurement development. Positive inertia includes an organisational culture linked to collaborative work, which contributes to developing knowledge, processes, and workflows for collaborating based on previous experiences.

At the connecting level, four drivers were mentioned by the interviewees: (1) control agencies' support, (2) political support, (3) political visibility (the most mentioned drivers at this level, with two mentions), and (4) shared procurement system. These connecting drivers depend on efforts from internal and external stakeholders to be developed. However, some drivers are more reactive and can be related to initiatives from external stakeholders (e.g., control agencies' support, political support and shared procurement system), while others are more proactive and can be related to initiatives from internal stakeholders (e.g., political visibility).

For instance, control agencies' support entails collaborative SPP initiatives assistance by public agencies responsible for procurement supervision, including interpreting regulations, attending brainstorm meetings, sharing best practices, and stimulating collaborative behaviour. Political support includes politicians' initiatives encouraging the uptake of collaboration in SPP, in a top-down approach. Shared procurement system comprises an e-procurement platform offered by a central agency to public buyers, including a repository of procurement documents (e.g., technical studies, interaction reports, market research, and procurement specifications and criteria), fostering knowledge sharing and networking. Political visibility stands for internal efforts bringing politicians' attention and obtaining political gains by using collaborative initiatives in SPP, which contributes to raising the strategic level of these initiatives through a bottom-up approach.

At the external level, the interviewees mentioned two drivers: (1) clear and supportive regulations and (2) market willingness. These external drivers depend mainly on external stakeholders' efforts to be developed. The most mentioned driver at the external level was clear and supportive regulations (two mentions). Clear and supportive regulations comprise collaboration mechanisms included in regulatory frameworks, supporting practitioners' decisions and providing a safe legal environment for collaborating with stakeholders.

The most mentioned drivers for collaboration in SPP considering the three levels were collaboration commitment (internal, eight mentions) and multidisciplinary team (internal, four mentions).

4.2 | Barriers to Collaboration in SPP

The interviewees mentioned 29 barriers to implementing collaboration in SPP, listed in Table 6—also categorised into internal, connecting, and external. At the internal level, 18 barriers were mentioned: (1) lack of attractiveness, (2) lack of category knowledge, (3) lack of clear responsibilities, (4) lack of collaboration commitment, (5) lack of cost–benefit balance, (6) lack of dedicated staff, (7) lack of guidelines, (8) lack of initiative, (9) lack of knowledge management, (10) lack of personal chemistry, (11) lack of personnel, (12) lack of risk-taking behaviour, (13) lack of stakeholder mapping, (14) lack of strategic positioning of procurement, (15) lack of supplier relationship policy, (16) lack of sustainability knowledge, (17) lack of time, and (18) lack of training. These internal barriers depict mainly internal resistance to change.

The most mentioned internal barriers were lack of personnel (seven mentions), lack of time (seven mentions), lack of collaboration commitment (six mentions), and lack of stakeholder mapping (six mentions). Lack of personnel includes a reduced workforce for engaging stakeholders and managing collaborative initiatives. Lack of time entails the absence of available time to work in collaborative initiatives, considering tight procurement schedules. Lack of collaboration commitment is related to a disseminated procurement culture of working isolated, which supports personnel's decisions aimed at ignoring opportunities to interact with stakeholders. Lack of stakeholder mapping comprises the absence of efforts to understand which stakeholders are related to each procurement category, limiting collaborative initiatives.

At the connecting level, the interviewees mentioned six barriers: (1) lack of expectations alignment, (2) lack of political support, (3) lack of political visibility, (4) lack of sustainability alignment, (5) lack of timing, and (6) lack of trust. The most mentioned barrier at this level was lack of trust (five mentions). These connecting barriers enact resistance to change based on internal and external stakeholders. However, some barriers can be more related to external stakeholders' lack of initiative (e.g., lack of political support), while others can be related to lack of initiative from internal stakeholders (e.g., lack of expectations alignment, lack of political visibility, lack of sustainability alignment, lack of timing, and lack of trust).

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TABLE 6 | Barriers to collaboration between stakeholders in SPP according to the interviewees.

Level	Barrier	Sources
External	Lack of end-user association	SE6
	Lack of policies and guidelines	BR3
	Lack of procurement knowledge	BR6
	Lack of supportive regulations	BR3, BR5
	Lack of willingness	BR3, BR4, BR6, BR9, BR10, BR12, SE2, SE3, SE8, SE9
Connecting	Lack of expectations alignment	SE5, SE6
	Lack of political support	BR3, SE5
	Lack of political visibility	BR9
	Lack of sustainability alignment	BR1, SE5
	Lack of timing	BR4, SE3
	Lack of trust	BR7, BR8, BR9, BR10, BR12
Internal	Lack of attractiveness	BR2, BR3, SE6
	Lack of category knowledge	BR10, SE9
	Lack of clear responsibilities	BR3, SE1
	Lack of collaboration commitment	BR4, BR6, BR8, BR9, SE5, SE7
	Lack of cost–benefit balance	BR3
	Lack of dedicated staff	BR2, BR9, BR10, BR12
	Lack of guidelines	BR4, SE2, SE3
	Lack of initiative	BR2, BR7
	Lack of knowledge management	SE3
	Lack of personal chemistry	SE8
	Lack of personnel	BR3, BR7, BR8, BR11, SE6, SE8, SE10
	Lack of risk-taking behaviour	BR4, SE8
	Lack of stakeholder mapping	BR3, BR7, BR12, SE3, SE4, SE5
	Lack of strategic positioning of procurement	BR2, BR5, BR7, BR9
	Lack of supplier relationship policy	BR9, BR12, SE1
	Lack of sustainability knowledge	BR8
	Lack of time	BR7, BR8, BR10, BR12, SE3, SE4, SE7
	Lack of training	BR9, BR12

For example, lack of political support stands for politicians' lack of support in empowering procurement officers to engage with stakeholders and using political networks to link internal to external stakeholders. Lack of expectations alignment entails stakeholders' frustration with the outcomes from collaborative initiatives—although they are willing to collaborate and may start interactions, engagements are dismantled when public buyers fail to align expectations regarding benefits from such initiatives. Lack of political visibility comprises an absence of efforts towards bringing politicians' attention to collaborative SPP initiatives, losing opportunities to raise such initiatives to a strategic level. Lack of sustainability alignment stands for divergent understandings of sustainability and its dimensions hindering collaboration, such as stakeholder dialogues being compromised by different focus (e.g., environmental vs. social priority). Lack of timing includes stakeholder dealignment concerning when to collaborate, such as potential suppliers' willingness to collaborate only after a buyer finishes a procurement process (postponing some benefits of such interactions) and public buyers unwilling to carry out a joint or centralised procurement due to their different expectations regarding supply starting time. Lack of trust entails fear of engaging with stakeholders through collaborative initiatives due to a perceived risk of corruption and cooptation.

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At the external level, five barriers were mentioned by the interviewees: (1) lack of end-users, (2) lack of policies and guidelines related to collaboration, (3) lack of procurement knowledge, (4) lack of supportive regulations, and (5) lack of willingness. These external barriers portray resistance to change posed mainly by the external system. Lack of willingness was the most mentioned external barrier (10 mentions) and stands for a perceived disbelief in the outcomes of collaborative initiatives leading to an unbalanced cost–benefit understanding of engaging in such initiatives, resulting in stakeholders avoiding interactions.

The most mentioned barriers to collaboration in SPP considering internal, connecting and external forces were lack of willingness (external, 10 mentions), lack of personnel (internal, 7 mentions), and lack of time (internal, 7 mentions).

4.3 | Strategies to Overcome Barriers to Collaboration in SPP

The interviewees mentioned 20 strategies to overcome barriers to implementing collaboration in SPP, listed in Table 7 and organised according to the internal-connecting-external categorisation. At the internal level, the interviewees mentioned 10 strategies: (1) annual procurement plan, (2) balanced workload, (3) collaboration between departments, (4) engagement through leaders, (5) incremental approach, (6) integrity plan, (7) multidisciplinary team, (8) process management, (9) socio-cultural specifications, and (10) training. These internal strategies require mainly internal efforts to be applied.

The most mentioned strategies at the internal level were collaboration between departments (two mentions), integrity plan (two mentions), and training (two mentions). Collaboration between departments comprises joint efforts between different departments to engage stakeholders and share additional work related to collaboration (e.g., coordinating interactions). Integrity plan stands for structured efforts towards fostering integrity, transparency, and risk management, which can contribute to building trust among stakeholders. Training entails specific development of personnel's collaboration skills, including stakeholder engagement and how to interpret procurement regulations to provide a safe environment for collaboration.

At the connecting level, 10 strategies were mentioned by the interviewees: (1) active networking, (2) associate political visibility, (3) control agencies' support, (4) formalised interactions, (5) incentives for participation (the most mentioned connecting strategy, with three mentions), (6) long-term approach, (7) peer pressure, (8) supplier training, (9) suppliers summit, and (10) triangulation. These connecting strategies require internal and external efforts to be developed. However, some strategies can be more related to initiatives from external stakeholders (e.g., control agencies' support), while others are more related to initiatives from internal stakeholders (e.g., active networking, associate political visibility, formalised interactions, incentives for participation, long-term approach, peer pressure, supplier training, suppliers summit, and triangulation).

TABLE 7 | Strategies to overcome barriers to collaboration between stakeholders in SPP according to the interviewees.

Level	Strategy	Sources
Connecting	Active networking	SE2, SE6
	Associate political visibility	BR9
	Formalised interactions	BR10
	Control agencies' support	BR4
	Incentives for participation	BR2, BR3, BR6
	Long-term approach	BR4, SE3
	Peer pressure	BR4
	Supplier training	BR4
	Suppliers summit	BR3, BR4
	Triangulation	BR6
Internal	Annual procurement plan	BR3
	Balanced workload	BR5
	Collaboration between departments	BR8, SE1
	Engagement through leaders	BR12
	Incremental approach	SE9
	Integrity plan	BR11, BR12
	Multidisciplinary team	BR6
	Process management	SE1
	Socio-cultural specifications	SE6
	Training	BR4, BR7

For instance, control agencies' support includes additional support from agencies responsible for procurement supervision, such as attending fairs and dialogues to help build trust between stakeholders. Active networking stands for procurement officers working closely with potential collaborators and using individual connections to engage with them, persistently. Associate political visibility comprises additional bottom-up efforts towards linking collaborative SPP initiatives with political gains, bringing politicians' attention and resources for developing collaboration. Formalised interactions include dialogues supported by formal procedures, such as meeting agendas published on a website, aiming to develop collaboration predictability and transparency. Incentives for participation entail actively informing potential collaborators regarding the benefits of engaging in collaborative SPP initiatives, such as a better understanding of procurement processes, mutual learning, and sharing needs. Long-term approach stands for efforts towards fostering collaboration by showing the benefits of continuous interactions and disseminating an understanding of collaboration as a more long- than short-term process. Peer pressure comprises procurement officers and managers informally engaging with their peers

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in other organisations to stimulate their participation in collaborative initiatives (e.g., joint procurement), building willingness to collaborate. Supplier training includes guidelines and training sessions offered by public buyers to potential suppliers, aiming to share collaboration procedures and benefits and build trust. Suppliers summit entails events promoted by public buyers to join suppliers, potential suppliers, control agencies, and other stakeholders in a transparent conversation related to sharing knowledge and discussing challenges on collaborative SPP initiatives. Triangulation stands for interacting with additional stakeholders to overcome resistance to collaboration, such as in engaging other buyers to gather market information when potential suppliers refuse to interact.

The interviewees did not mention external strategies, which require mainly external efforts to be developed. The most mentioned strategy, considering the internal and connecting levels, was to offer incentives for participation (three mentions, connecting).

5 | Discussion

5.1 | Forces Influencing Organisational Changes for Collaboration in SPP

Implementing collaboration between stakeholders in SPP initiatives requires organisational changes, which are influenced by forces contributing to and hindering change processes. This research identifies and categorises these forces (i.e., drivers for, barriers to collaboration in SPP, and strategies to overcome such barriers) to provide a more complete understanding of changes towards collaboration in SPP.

This paper collates 23 drivers that contribute to moving organisations towards implementing collaboration between stakeholders in SPP, of which 10 drivers (5 mentioned by the interviewees and 5 not mentioned) were previously identified in the literature (see Table 1) and 13 new drivers were mentioned by the interviewees but not identified in previous research—complementing the literature. A variety of barriers can hinder change efforts towards implementing collaboration in SPP, including the 40 barriers identified by this paper, of which 21 (10 mentioned by the interviewees and 11 not mentioned) were previously identified in the literature (see Table 2) and 19 new barriers were mentioned by the interviewees but not identified in previous research, expanding the literature. Several strategies can contribute to overcoming barriers to implementing collaboration in SPP, such as the 24 strategies collated by this paper, comprising 5 strategies (1 mentioned by the interviewees and 4 not mentioned) previously identified in the literature (see Table 3) and 19 new strategies (i.e., not identified in previous research), which complement research efforts. Table 8 presents the comparison between the forces identified in the empirical data and previous literature.

The analysis of the forces influencing the uptake of collaborative SPP initiatives highlights that interactions between stakeholders are an intrinsic element of organisational changes (c.f. Doppelt 2010; Freeman 1984)—several drivers, barriers, and strategies are dependent on stakeholder interactions to be developed and understood, considering internal, connecting, and external categories. However, the empirical data suggest a new categorisation can be offered to improve the understanding of such forces, considering a more fluid relationship between internal and external stakeholders and their systems. For example, internal forces can require external stakeholders to be developed (e.g., training by external education) and external forces can be influenced by changing organisations (e.g., regulations being developed after inputs from an organisation's internal stakeholders). Nonetheless, the level of external stakeholder dependence and organisational influence on such forces can vary. A new categorisation can explicitly consider these elements, their intersections, and organisations' role in linking the internal to external systems.

This paper proposes a new categorisation of change forces—based on a holistic approach to those forces influencing organisational changes towards collaboration in SPP—to provide more depth to the links between internal and external systems, from a changing organisation perspective. This categorisation entails an internal level, that is, more dependent on internal stakeholders (i.e., high organisational influence), and an external level, that is, more dependent on external stakeholders (i.e., limited organisational influence). This categorisation also includes a connecting level that entails forces more dependent on both internal and external stakeholders and their systems (concurring with Lozano 2015; Lozano et al. 2019). However, this new categorisation expands the literature by arranging connecting forces into two sets, according to which role an organisation can perform to link the internal to external systems: protagonist (i.e., more related to internal stakeholder initiatives and medium organisational influence) and supporting (i.e., more related to external stakeholder initiatives and low organisational influence). Figure 1 presents the SPP Change Forces System—ChaFoS, a holistic approach to forces influencing organisational changes towards collaboration in SPP that explicitly considers stakeholder dependence and organisational influence.

The drivers for and barriers to collaboration in SPP, as well as strategies to overcome such barriers, can be organised according to the ChaFoS (see Table 9) for visualising the complete set of forces influencing organisational changes for collaboration between stakeholders in SPP.

The analysis of the forces collated by this paper suggests that organisational changes for collaboration in SPP have been carried out in different contexts, comprising similarities in how organisations embark on such changes to improve SPP implementation (e.g., several forces are common between Brazilian and Swedish contexts). However, there are some differences between the change approaches adopted in these contexts, which can be understood by analysing the context-related forces. For instance, some drivers linked to the Brazilian context are more related to practitioner-based efforts (in agreement with Delmonico et al. 2018; Santos, Lozano, and Barreiro-Gen 2024), such as control agencies' support and professional visibility. Some barriers identified by the Brazilian interviewees are also related to a context based on practical efforts, such as lack of external policies and guidelines, lack of trust, lack of dedicated staff, and lack of strategic positioning

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TABLE 8 | Comparison between the forces identified in the empirical data and previous literature.

Comparison	Driver	Barrier	Strategy
Previously identified in the literature and mentioned by the interviewees	(1) Champions (see Lingegård et al. 2021; Lozano et al. 2020), (2) collaboration-friendly policy (c.f. Johnson and Klassen 2022), (3) leadership (see Lingegård et al. 2021), (4) long planning phase (c.f. Lozano et al. 2020; Uttam and Roos 2015) and (5) stakeholder mapping (see Alhola and Nissinen 2018; Holma et al. 2020; Johnson and Klassen 2022)	(1) Lack of category knowledge (see Lingegård et al. 2021), (2) lack of collaboration commitment (c.f. Erridge and Greer 2002), (3) lack of expectations alignment (see Sattari et al. 2022), (4) lack of risk-taking behaviour (c.f. Erridge and Greer 2002; Holma et al. 2020), (5) lack of strategic positioning of procurement (see Erridge and Greer 2002), (6) lack of supportive regulations (c.f. Edquist and Zabala-Iturriagagoitia 2012; Erridge and Greer 2002; Lingegård et al. 2021), (7) lack of sustainability alignment (see Bratt et al. 2013), (8) lack of time (c.f. Holma et al. 2020; Lingegård et al. 2021), (9) lack of training (see Erridge and Greer 2002; Holma et al. 2020; Preuss and Walker 2011) and (10) lack of trust (c.f. Erridge and Greer 2002; Sonnino 2009)	(1) Training (c.f. Erridge and Greer 2002)
Previously identified in the literature but not mentioned by the interviewees	(1) Clear roles (c.f. Bortz et al. 2024; Johnson and Klassen 2022), (2) innovation hub (see Johnson and Klassen 2022), (3) demand-offering of needs (c.f. Lozano et al. 2020; Uttam and Roos 2015), (4) discretion (see Sparrevik et al. 2018) and (5) socio-cultural specifications (c.f. Alhola and Nissinen 2018)	(1) Lack of clear roles (see Bratt et al. 2013; Holma et al. 2020), (2) lack of common goals (c.f. Erridge and Greer 2002; Preuss and Walker 2011), (3) lack of competitive market (see Preuss and Walker 2011), (4) lack of early involvement (c.f. Holma et al. 2020), (5) lack of employee retention (see Erridge and Greer 2002), (6) lack of informal arrangements (c.f. Erridge and Greer 2002), (7) lack of initiative hub (see Preuss and Walker 2011), (8) lack of interaction transparency (c.f. Bratt et al. 2013), (9) lack of long-term thinking (see Bratt et al. 2013), (10) lack of participative-building internal policies (c.f. Erridge and Greer 2002) and (11) lack of positive inertia (see Erridge and Greer 2002)	(1) Discretion, (2) participative-building internal policies, (3) professionalisation of procurement staff and (4) strategic positioning of procurement (c.f. Erridge and Greer 2002)
New forces (i.e., not identified in previous research)	(1) Balanced workload, (2) clear and supportive regulations, (3) collaboration commitment, (4) control agencies' support, (5) dedicated staff, (6) innovation culture, (7) market willingness, (8) multidisciplinary team, (9) political support, (10) political visibility, (11) positive inertia, (12) professional visibility and (13) shared procurement system	(1) Lack of attractiveness, (2) lack of clear responsibilities, (3) lack of cost–benefit balance, (4) lack of dedicated staff, (5) lack of end-user association, (6) lack of guidelines, (7) lack of initiative, (8) lack of knowledge management, (9) lack of personal chemistry, (10) lack of personnel, (11) lack of policies and guidelines, (12) lack of political support, (13) lack of political visibility, (14) lack of procurement knowledge, (15) lack of stakeholder mapping, (16) lack of supplier relationship policy, (17) lack of sustainability knowledge, (18) lack of timing and (19) lack of willingness	(1) Active networking, (2) annual procurement plan, (3) associate political visibility, (4) balanced workload, (5) collaboration between departments, (6) control agencies' support, (7) engagement through leaders, (8) formalised interactions, (9) incentives for participation, (10) incremental approach, (11) integrity plan, (12) long-term approach, (13) multidisciplinary team, (14) peer pressure, (15) process management, (16) socio-cultural specifications, (17) supplier training, (18) suppliers summit and (19) triangulation

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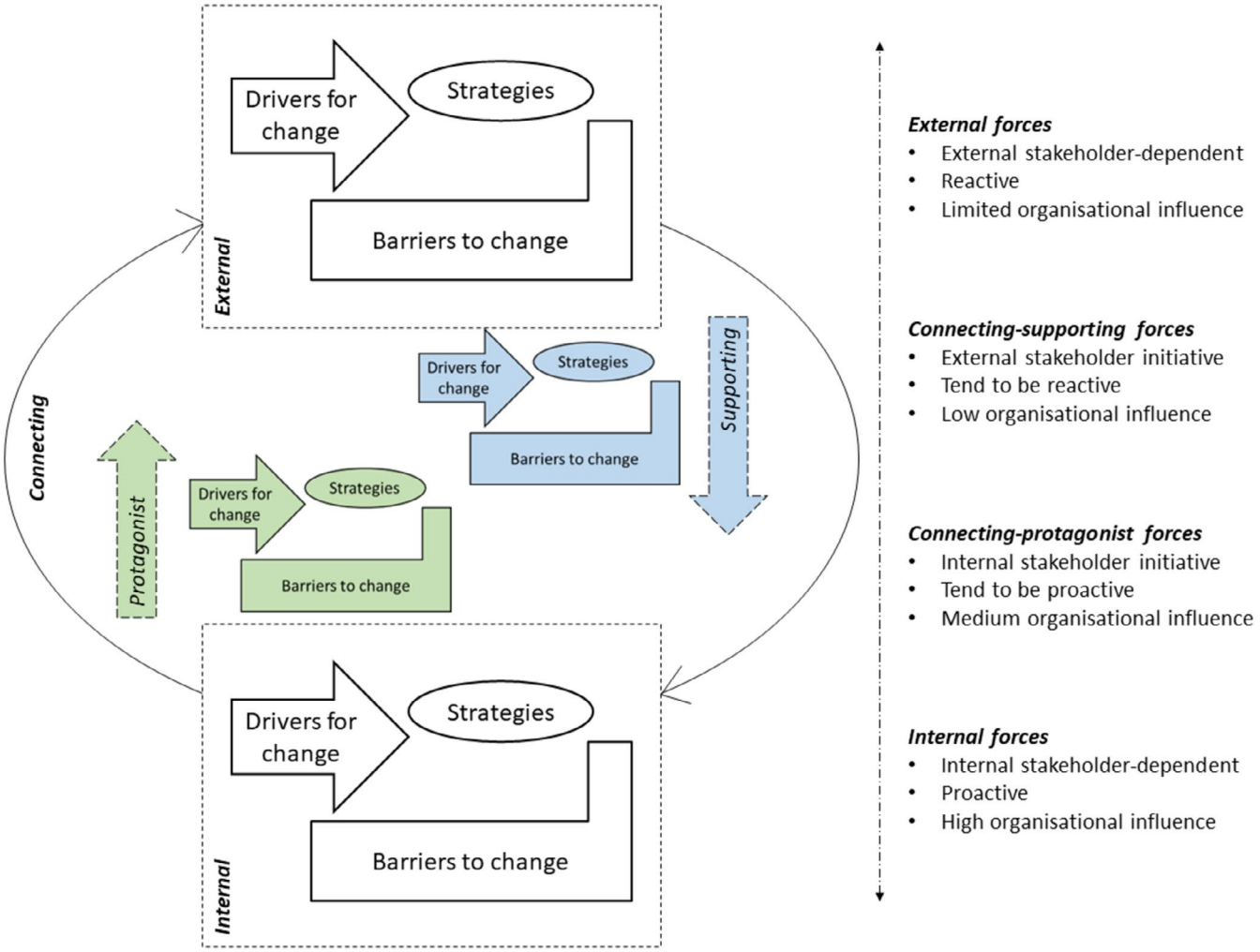


FIGURE 1 | SPP change forces system.

of procurement. Most of the strategies developed by Brazilian organisations also relate to the same practical context, such as associate political visibility, control agencies' support, incentives for participation, supplier training, triangulation, and integrity plan. The specific forces influencing the Swedish context are more related to policy efforts (concurring with Daugbjerg 2023; Sattari et al. 2022). For example, dedicated staff, long planning phase, and positive inertia can be identified as policy-based drivers. Barriers such as lack of end-user association, lack of expectations alignment, and lack of knowledge management can be linked to policy contexts. Strategies such as active networking and incremental approaches can be related to policy support.

The number of forces influencing each context can also be highlighted: 8 drivers, 11 barriers, and 14 strategies were identified in the praxis-driven context; 4 drivers, 4 barriers, and 4 strategies were linked to the policy-driven context, and 6 drivers, 14 barriers, and 2 strategies are related to both contexts. These numbers suggest that praxis-driven contexts can face more resistance to implementing collaboration in SPP than policy-driven ones. However, the practical approach seems to stimulate the development of strategies, considering the higher number of strategies linked to praxis-driven contexts, compared to policy-driven ones. Synergies between both contexts can be identified (e.g., organisations from policy-driven contexts can learn praxis-based strategies to improve their change processes when policy support may be reduced; organisations from praxis-driven contexts can develop policy-based strategies to advocate for more policy support), reinforced by the number of common forces—changes for collaboration require policy and practical efforts and may not be limited by contexts.

The findings of this research also contribute to a better understanding of the malleability of interconnections between forces influencing organisational changes towards collaboration in SPP. For instance, the empirical data show multiple interconnections between barriers and strategies to overcome them—linking different forces, at different levels, in a malleable way (e.g., incentives for participation, a connecting-protagonist strategy, have been used to overcome lack of attractiveness, an internal barrier, and lack of willingness, an external barrier). These inter-level connections suggest that barriers to collaboration in SPP may not be overcome only by using specific or same-level strategies but also by developing a set of strategies that can holistically tackle hindering forces. The interconnections between barriers to SPP and strategies to

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TABLE 9 | Forces influencing the organisational change process towards collaboration in sustainable public procurement.

Level	Driver	Barrier	Strategy
External	Clear and supportive regulations	Lack of competitive market	
	Market willingness	Lack of end-user association	
		Lack of policies and guidelines	
		Lack of procurement knowledge	
		Lack of supportive regulations	
		Lack of willingness	
Connecting-supporting	Control agencies' support	Lack of initiative hub	Control agencies' support
	Political support	Lack of political support	
	Shared procurement system		
Connecting-protagonist	Clear roles	Lack of clear roles	Active networking
	Innovation hub	Lack of early involvement	Associate political visibility
	Political visibility	Lack of expectations alignment	Formalised interactions
		Lack of informal arrangements	Incentives for participation
		Lack of interaction transparency	Long-term approach
		Lack of participative-building internal policies	Participative-building internal policies
		Lack of political visibility	Peer pressure
		Lack of sustainability alignment	Suppliers summit
		Lack of timing	Supplier training
		Lack of trust	Triangulation
Internal	Balanced workload	Lack of attractiveness	Annual procurement plan
	Champions	Lack of category knowledge	Balanced workload
	Collaboration commitment	Lack of clear responsibilities	Collaboration between departments
	Collaboration-friendly policy	Lack of collaboration commitment	Discretion
	Dedicated staff	Lack of common goals	Engagement through leaders
	Demand-offering of needs	Lack of cost–benefit balance	Incremental approach
	Discretion	Lack of dedicated staff	Integrity plan
	Innovation culture	Lack of employee retention	Multidisciplinary team
	Leadership	Lack of guidelines	Process management
	Long planning phase	Lack of initiative	Professionalisation of procurement staff
	Multidisciplinary team	Lack of knowledge management	Socio-cultural specifications
	Positive inertia	Lack of long-term thinking	Strategic positioning of procurement
	Professional visibility	Lack of personal chemistry	Training
	Socio-cultural specifications	Lack of personnel	
	Stakeholder mapping	Lack of positive inertia	
		Lack of risk-taking behaviour	
		Lack of stakeholder mapping	
		Lack of strategic positioning of procurement	
		Lack of supplier relationship policy	
		Lack of sustainability knowledge	
		Lack of time	
		Lack of training	

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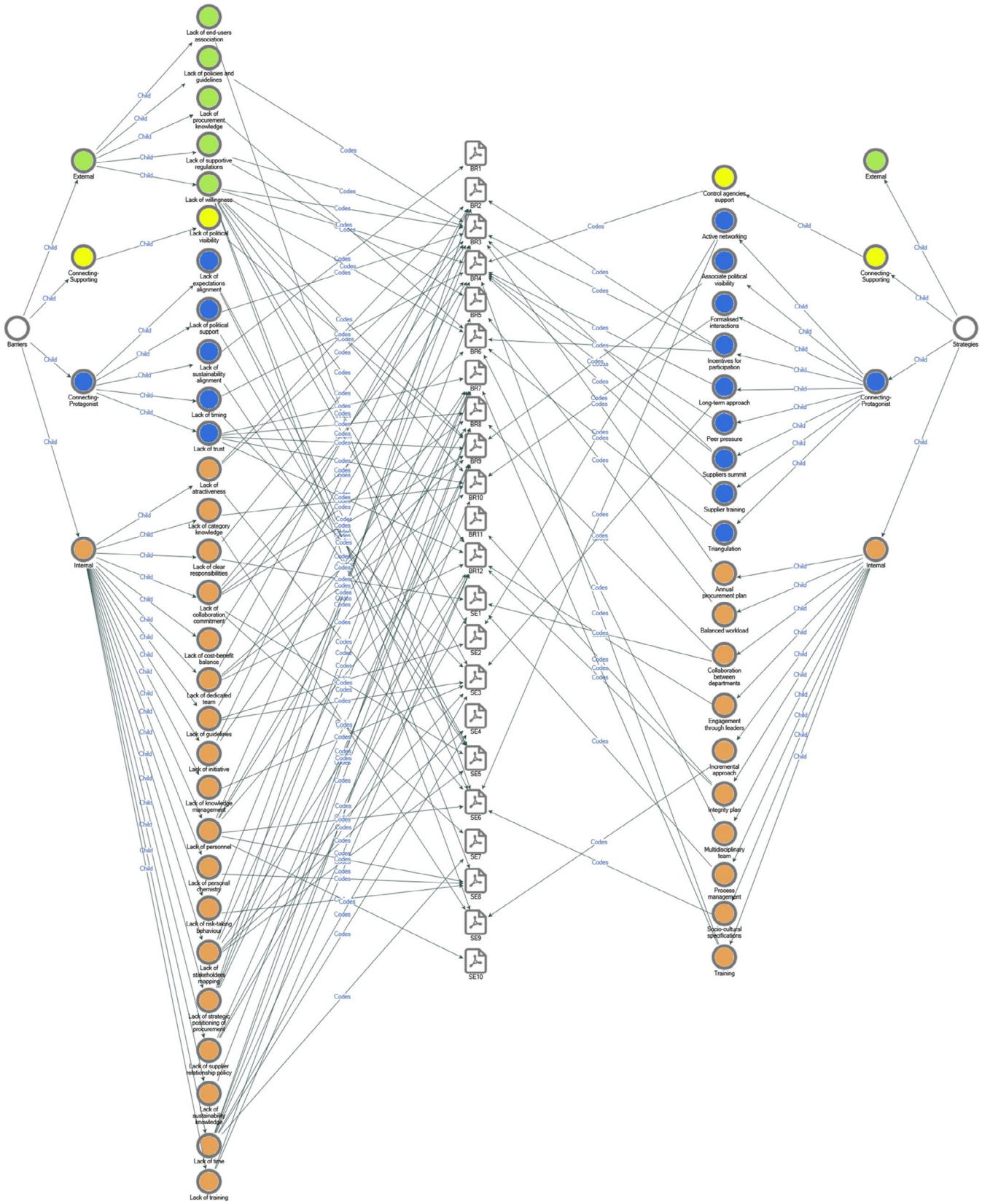


FIGURE 2 | Map of interconnections between barriers to collaboration in SPP and strategies to overcome them.

overcome barriers can be visualised in Figure 2. This visualisation, based on the findings of this research and presented through an NVivo map of codes, includes the following structures: barriers (left), barrier level, each barrier, interview sources (centre), each strategy, strategy level, and strategies (right). Different colours were used to identify force levels.

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5.2 | Nested Organisational Changes for Implementing SPP

The findings of this research also contribute to improving the knowledge of OCM in the SPP context by offering an understanding of simultaneous change processes contributing to moving organisations towards implementing SPP. Organisations can change for implementing SPP but, if they intend to use a key driver such as collaboration between stakeholders, an additional and specific change must be carried out (in agreement with Erridge and Greer 2002). The change process for implementing collaboration in SPP can be understood as derived from the main change towards SPP, suggesting that other change processes may be needed to use additional forces in that main change.

The understanding of these multiple changes in SPP is complemented by a comparison between the 51 drivers for SPP (proposed by Santos, Lozano, and Barreiro-Gen 2024) and the 23 drivers for implementing collaboration in SPP collated by this research (see Table 9)—only one common driver has been influencing both changes: collaboration commitment. Most of the drivers are related to each change process (e.g., political support for SPP can be different from political support for collaborating in SPP; champions in SPP can be different from champions in collaborating), which suggests that different forces have been influencing these change processes and reinforces the understanding of their distinction.

The change processes derived from and linked to the main change can be defined as nested changes, which may share some forces with the main change but are mainly influenced by different ones. For instance, the drivers influencing changes towards collaboration in SPP (i.e., a nested change) are mainly different from the drivers for moving organisations towards implementing SPP (i.e., a main change). The concept of nested changes expands the concept of multiple change processes (see Pettigrew, Woodman, and Cameron 2001) and adds to the OCM literature by considering that some change processes can be multiple and composite (by comprising main and nested changes) instead of single and monolithic.

Figure 3 presents a framework for understanding nested organisational changes in the context of implementing SPP, based on a simplified version of the framework proposed by Lozano (2007) for orchestrating changes for organisational sustainability and considering the different forces influencing the main and nested change processes. This framework includes organisational changes for collaboration in SPP as a nested change.

This research also adds to the literature by expanding the dimensions of organisational capacity for change (c.f. Meyer and Stensaker 2006), highlighting the need to build the capability to implement changes within main changes. In the context of nested changes (such as changes for SPP), the success of change processes can be increased by developing four dimensions of organisational capacity for change: capability to implement the main change, capability to maintain the operations, capability to implement nested changes, and capability to implement subsequent (i.e., future) changes.

6 | Conclusions

SPP has been using governments' purchasing power to foster sustainable consumption and production, contributing to sustainability efforts. Several disciplinary approaches support SPP implementation, including a managerial one that consists of efforts to manage and understand organisational changes for SPP. A key driver for changes towards implementing SPP is collaboration between stakeholders. However, implementing collaborative SPP also requires organisational changes, but there is limited research analysing changes towards using collaboration in SPP. Additionally, the literature has not yet provided an

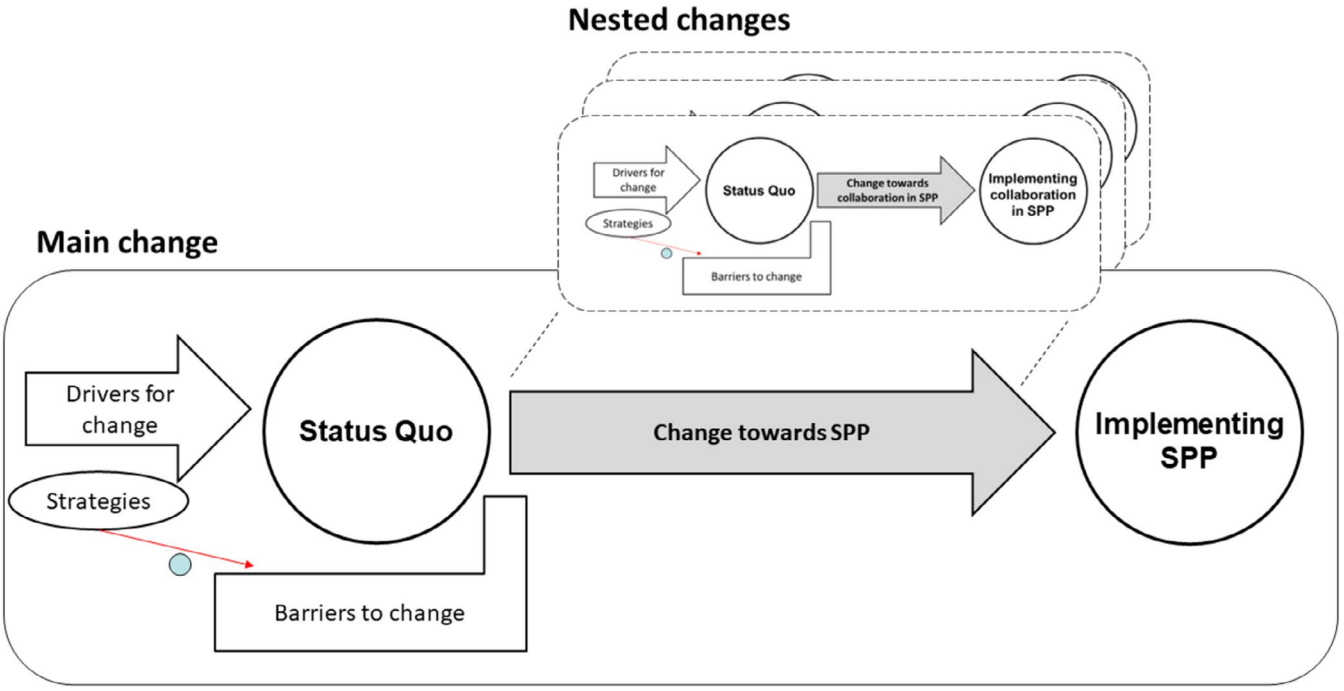


FIGURE 3 | Nested organisational changes in the context of implementing sustainable public procurement.

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understanding of the intersections between changes for SPP and changes for collaboration in SPP.

This research provides a catalogue of the whole set of forces influencing organisational changes towards collaboration in SPP, including 23 drivers, 40 barriers, and 24 strategies to overcome such barriers. These forces were categorised into internal, connecting-protagonist, connecting-supporting, and external, offering a holistic approach that understands organisations as whole systems interconnected in broad systems (in this case, the SPP system). This set of forces can be used to support further research and practice efforts aimed at understanding and implementing collaborative SPP initiatives through an OCM perspective.

The analysis of how the barriers to collaboration in SPP and strategies to overcome such barriers are interrelated, considering the different categories (i.e., internal, connecting-protagonist, connecting-supporting, and external), contributes to understanding the malleability of such forces. This malleability suggests that barriers hindering change efforts towards collaboration in SPP may require developing a set of strategies that can holistically tackle such forces.

This research also adds to the literature by offering an understanding of how organisational changes for collaboration in SPP are interconnected with changes for implementing SPP, the former deriving from the latter. Both changes have been driven by mainly different forces, reinforcing the understanding of these changes as separate but linked processes. This research offers the concept of nested changes to better understand these simultaneous change processes, considering change processes for SPP as multiple and composite instead of single and monolithic. This paper also contributes to OCM research by improving the dimensions of organisational capacities for changes, proposing the capability to implement nested changes as a dimension that can increase the success of some change processes.

This research also contributes to practitioners' efforts to implement collaboration in SPP by offering a catalogue of forces influencing organisational changes towards collaboration in this context. This set of forces can be used to plan organisational changes for collaboration in SPP, considering a more complete approach to how organisations and their stakeholders influence such forces. For instance, organisations moving towards implementing collaboration should develop the drivers proposed by this research and identify the barriers that can be hindering their efforts, considering the catalogue of forces. Strategies can be developed, using the catalogue as a basis, for overcoming the barriers to change. The malleability of such forces can contribute to practical efforts aiming at overcoming barriers by fostering systemic development of sets of forces instead of focusing on specific ones—such as building different level strategies to overcome single-level barriers. Each stakeholder in the SPP context can also use the catalogue of forces provided by this paper to develop efforts towards contributing to changes for collaboration—for instance, businesses can drive collaboration by improving their willingness to interact and reduce resistance to collaboration by engaging governments to acquire procurement knowledge, align expectations and sustainability understandings, and promote a trust-based relationship.

This research also supports a better implementation of SPP and collaboration by offering an understanding of the simultaneous change processes in complex contexts such as SPP, in which organisational changes can be multiple and composite. The nested changes concept can help practitioners implement changes in the SPP context and develop capacities for change in their organisations, avoiding simplifications that consider changes for SPP as single and monolithic. A better understanding of organisational changes for SPP and collaboration can contribute to increasing the success of change initiatives, resulting in more effective SPP initiatives and their contribution to developing sustainable societies. Collaboration can improve SPP initiatives in different contexts by joining efforts from governments, businesses, and other stakehodlers towards implementing SPP.

This research should be followed up with quantitative studies aimed at ranking and offering a more complete analysis of the interconnections between the forces influencing organisational changes for collaboration between stakeholders in SPP (e.g., barriers vs. strategies). More depth should be provided on the specific drivers, barriers, and strategies organised by this research. Additional studies on forces influencing organisational changes for SPP should be conducted to analyse which forces require nested changes. Other contexts of organisational changes towards sustainability should be analysed through a nested changes approach aiming at building knowledge on multiple and simultaneous change processes.

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